Void Calling

Void Calling

Void Calling, also called the **Star Plague**, is an occult disease encountered during travel beyond natural planetary atmospheres. Early symptoms can interrupt ordinary shipboard work: someone hears a relative calling through a ventilation grille, or repeatedly checks an exterior camera for a person the other watch officer cannot see. Over several days, the afflicted may become suspicious of their crewmates and try to leave the vessel to reach whoever they believe is outside.

This slower exposure syndrome can develop into true Void Calling after the victim enters vacuum. The true form causes severe weakness and confusion within minutes, followed by death and transformation into a Void-Drawn. Survivors sometimes retain physical changes associated with the Void-Returned archetype. Settled Systems Code `A9%11&4-6` classifies the disease as **vacuum-associated cognitive exposure syndrome**, usually shortened to **vacuum sickness** in official reports.

Shared Affliction Rules

Natural planetary atmosphere

Either form becomes **dormant immediately** within a natural planetary atmosphere. A toxic or unbreathable atmosphere qualifies, including while the person is inside a sealed habitat on that world. Use the setting's atmosphere boundary; trace gas in near-vacuum does not qualify. Air maintained aboard a ship, station, or spacesuit outside that boundary provides ordinary life support while the affliction remains active.

Track the form, current stage, and remaining onset or stage interval. Timers continue during dormancy, and the GM resolves stage saves privately at their normal intervals, retaining any pending virulent success. Use ordinary save outcomes, subject to the cosmic carrier rules below: the infection can improve, worsen, or be cured by recovery below stage 1. Suppress its stage effects, vacuum adaptation, and transmission throughout dormancy. Injuries and Hit Points already lost require ordinary recovery.

A living creature that reaches true Void Calling's stage 4 in atmosphere remains alive and attempts another stage save each minute. Failed saves hold it at stage 4. Leaving atmosphere applies the current stage's effects immediately and preserves the remaining interval; leaving at stage 4 causes death unless cosmic protection suppresses it. A creature that died before entering atmosphere remains dead, with its transformation countdown paused until departure.

A dormant infection is **undetectable**, so examinations during dormancy are inconclusive. The GM keeps progression and recovery results private. Previous symptoms and exposure records can justify suspicion.

The Drift

Travel within the Drift prevents new exposure to either form. Crews commonly believe that entering it also suppresses an existing infection.

Cosmic carriers

A creature that contracts either form while it has the cosmic trait begins at **stage 1** after any onset, even on a critically failed initial save. The trait suppresses harmful stage effects and prevents failed or critically failed stage saves from increasing the stage in either environment. An infection acquired while cosmic stays capped at stage 1. Transmission follows the usual environmental rules.

Gaining the cosmic trait while already infected preserves the infection's current stage and remaining interval. It functions as a stage-1 carrier for transmission. At each normal stage interval, successful saves reduce the recorded stage, applying virulent normally; failures leave it unchanged. Outside a natural planetary atmosphere, recovery stops at stage 1, where intervals continue without a roll.

Within a natural planetary atmosphere, continue recovery saves at the normal intervals, including at stage 1. Recovery below stage 1 cures the infection; failures and critical failures leave its stage unchanged. If the cosmic trait ends, apply the current stage's effects unless atmospheric dormancy suppresses them. Preserve the remaining interval and any pending virulent success.

Transmission and exposure checks

Transmission begins at stage 1. For an ongoing exposure source, make the initial save when the stated exposure duration is completed, then once per additional 24 hours while that source persists. A discrete attack or hazardous manifestation uses its own exposure instruction. An existing infection follows its stage timer; repeated exposure to that same form does not accelerate it.

A creature can carry one form at a time. If a creature with Exposure contracts true Void Calling, replace Exposure with the true form. On a successful initial save against the true form, retain its existing Exposure stage and timer.

Saves and recovery

Use the usual affliction rules: an initial failure produces stage 1, and an initial critical failure produces stage 2 after any onset. At each stage interval, a failure increases the stage by 1 and a critical failure by 2. A success reduces it by 1 and a critical success by 2, subject to virulent. Within a natural planetary atmosphere, recovering below stage 1 cures the infection. Outside it, recovery saves stop at **stage 1** for every creature. Effects that counteract or remove disease can cure an infection in either environment.

A virulent affliction requires two consecutive successful stage saves for a one-stage reduction. A critical success reduces the stage by 1 immediately. After a reduction or a failed save, start a fresh count. Initial saves use their normal results.

Void Calling Exposure

VOID CALLING, EXPOSURE — DISEASE 6

DISEASE MENTAL OCCULT

The afflicted hears familiar voices through machinery noise or the exterior hull. As the syndrome develops, those voices become easier to recognize than the people aboard the vessel.

Exposure Spending 24 consecutive hours outside a natural planetary atmosphere and the Drift aboard a vessel or habitat without a functioning void-grounding protocol; spending 8 consecutive hours aboard the same occupied vessel or habitat as a creature with an active stage-1-or-higher infection; or an exposure ability of a Void-Drawn.

Saving Throw DC 22 Will

Onset 3 days

Virulent proximity This form gains virulent for stage saves made within 30 feet of another active carrier of either form. If that proximity ends, the next save uses ordinary recovery rules and clears any pending virulent success.

Stage 1 Asymptomatic carrier. (1 day)

Stage 2 Stupefied 1. A familiar voice seems to speak through ventilation, machinery, or the hull. (4 hours)

Stage 3 Stupefied 1. Before taking a move action that would bring you within 10 feet of another creature, attempt a DC 5 flat check. On a failure, the action is lost. (4 hours)

Stage 4 As stage 3, and other creatures are hidden from you. A creature within your reach is observed. A creature within 30 feet becomes observed from the moment it uses a move or manipulate action until the end of its turn. These are the ways this stage allows a creature to become observed. (1 day)

Stage 5 As stage 4, with the airlock compulsion below. (1 hour)

Airlock compulsion At the start of your turn in an encounter, or once per 10 minutes during exploration, attempt a DC 22 Will save. These are compulsion saves and do not change the disease's stage.

Critical Success or Success You act normally.

Failure Spend your first available action moving toward the nearest known route into open space. If adjacent to its access mechanism, use that action to Interact with it.

Critical Failure Spend all available actions pursuing that route and operating its access mechanisms.

If you know no route, the GM describes the direction indicated by the hallucination. The required movement follows that direction. This is a compulsion effect.

Vacuum escalation Entering vacuum at any active stage exposes you to true Void Calling, including while wearing a spacesuit. If this form becomes active while you are already in vacuum, resolve that exposure immediately. Make at most one initial save per 24 hours from this trigger.

True Void Calling

VOID CALLING — DISEASE 10

DISEASE MENTAL OCCULT VIRULENT

True Void Calling develops immediately after a failed initial save. Breathing stops or becomes irregular, the victim's limbs weaken, and their responses become slow and confused. They may continue describing people or structures visible only to them.

Exposure Vacuum escalation from Void Calling, Exposure; spending 10 minutes within 30 feet of a Void-Drawn; or direct exposure to a powerful manifestation designated by the GM. Ordinary proximity to a living carrier exposes a susceptible creature to the slower Exposure form.

Saving Throw DC 27 Will

Onset Immediate

Vacuum adaptation Throughout active stages 1–3, you can survive the basic environmental effects of vacuum and function without breathing there.

Stage 1 Stupefied 1 and enfeebled 1. (1 minute)

Stage 2 Stupefied 2, enfeebled 2, and slowed 1. You gain resistance 5 to cold and void damage. (1 minute)

Stage 3 Stupefied 3, enfeebled 3, and slowed 2. Your resistance to cold and void damage is 10. Your limbs respond slowly, and speaking requires considerable effort. (1 minute)

Stage 4 Death. After 1d4 rounds, the body rises as a Void-Drawn under the GM's control. While this stage is suppressed, a living patient continues stage saves at 1-minute intervals.

An initial failure followed by ordinary failed stage saves causes death after 3 minutes. Critical failures can shorten that interval to 1 minute.

Nature of the Affliction

Void Calling spreads through an occult interaction between minds. Several people aboard a vessel may describe someone standing outside the same viewport, with each witness recognizing a different person. Medical investigators use these related accounts to trace outbreaks; efforts to isolate a consistent organism have been inconclusive.

Long driftless voyages create repeated opportunities for exposure, especially when crew members sleep poorly or work alone for extended periods. An asymptomatic carrier can expose crewmates aboard a well-run vessel.

Entering a natural planetary atmosphere suppresses the infection. A patient can recover clear speech and recognize their companions while still carrying the disease, whose effects return at its current stage if they depart while still infected. This makes exposure records important during crew transfers: a medical examination conducted planetside yields an inconclusive result even for an infected traveler.

Hallucinations

The hallucinations use people and situations the victim remembers. A crew member might hear a missing relative asking for help outside a maintenance lock, using a familiar nickname. Someone accustomed to rescue work might see a stranded worker pointing to damaged equipment and move to collect a suit before mentioning the sighting to anyone else.

As symptoms worsen, the victim may struggle to recognize the people helping them. A familiar crewmate's face appears wrong, or their movements seem delayed. The person outside remains recognizable, and an attempt to restrain the victim can look like an obstruction to an urgent rescue.

Recognition and Diagnosis

Outside a natural planetary atmosphere, Medicine can identify the recurring symptoms and Occultism can identify the influence during a structured examination. An examination takes 1 minute and uses a secret check against the form's DC: 22 for Exposure or 27 for true Void Calling. Medicine requires a medkit and physical access to the subject. Occultism requires the subject to be conscious, cooperative, and able to communicate with the examiner. Success identifies the active form and stage; failure is inconclusive.

Record someone who previously tested positive as a suspected dormant carrier until a cure or an active-state examination resolves their status.

Watch logs can help identify the first symptoms. Repeated requests to inspect an exterior hatch warrant an assessment when the person also reports interrupted sleep or a familiar voice outside. During true Void Calling, weakening limbs and delayed responses make treatment urgent; another caregiver can examine the patient while assistance begins.

Crews check reported exterior emergencies against independent sensors before opening an airlock. An afflicted witness can still report a real accident, so their condition becomes part of the assessment alongside camera footage, pressure readings, and the location of other personnel.

Prevention

Long-voyage crews work paired watches and check one another's sleep and recent observations during handover. Grounding protocols maintain a regular daily routine and limit time spent alone watching open space. Some vessels cover viewports during rest periods and use artificial horizon displays to help the crew remain oriented.

Exterior access requires an independent check of the reported problem and authorization from a second person. Mechanical locks keep the airlock secured during a software failure. A crew member showing credible symptoms is relieved of flight-critical duties while someone stays with them and arranges an assessment. Navigators keep a diversion toward a natural planetary atmosphere available when the route permits it.

Before departure, crew members choose **anchors** they can use during a grounding check. An anchor can be a shared memory or a familiar object. A caregiver might discuss a repair they completed together while checking the patient’s awareness of their present location.

Treatment

Treat Disease uses its normal eight-hour activity to prepare for a subsequent stage save. Grounding Check provides a shorter way to prepare for a stage save. During true Void Calling's minute-long intervals, use Emergency Grounding below, a suitable disease-removal effect, or rapid transport into a natural atmosphere.

Effects that counteract or remove diseases can cure either form, including a dormant infection, if their targeting requirements are met. For counteracting, Exposure is rank 3 at DC 22 and true Void Calling is rank 5 at DC 27. Treatment that improves stage saves follows the environmental recovery rules. An effect used on a suspected dormant carrier gives no diagnostic confirmation of infection or cure while the target remains in atmosphere; the GM tracks the result privately. Disease-removal effects apply to pending transformation only if their normal targeting permits affecting the body.

Caregivers bring a patient with Exposure to a compartment with covered viewports and supervised exits. Someone familiar stays with them, explains where they are, and checks reported emergencies with the rest of the crew. During the true disease's crisis, attendants clear space around the patient and prepare for immediate transport. A patient being cured in vacuum needs a functioning suit or other environmental protection as the disease's vacuum adaptation ends.

Settled Systems Classification

Settled Systems Code `A9%11&4-6`, the **Extended-Voyage Cognitive Exposure and Quarantine Standard**, sets the minimum precautions for registered long-voyage vessels. Operators must maintain watch records and an approved grounding protocol, restrict airlock access, and provide a procedure for relieving symptomatic personnel. An afflicted person with control of navigation or exterior doors can endanger everyone aboard, making supervision an immediate operational concern.

The standard also requires records of unexplained exterior alarms and provision for treatment or diversion toward a natural planetary atmosphere. Exposure at stage 3 or higher requires a formal incident report, as does every episode of true Void Calling. Medical records must distinguish dormant infection from confirmed cure so the next crew can plan for a patient's departure from atmosphere.

These records affect liability after an outbreak. An operator with signed acknowledgments and complete grounding logs can attribute a loss to a worker's failure to follow procedure. Incomplete records can cost a vessel its insurance or docking eligibility, and survivors may lose compensation even when equipment failed.

Quarantine procedures call for supervision and sensory grounding. On ships with limited medical staff or spare compartments, security personnel often sedate a patient and restrain them alone. The arrangement leaves the patient with fewer opportunities to compare their perceptions with another person and reduces the crew's ability to notice a worsening condition.

Discovery

The earliest human and dwarven voyage records after the Star Dream contain no accounts of Void Calling. Those crews traveled comparatively short routes near inhabited systems and stayed in close contact while learning to operate their vessels. The first surviving descriptions of the disease come from expeditions beyond the region now recognized as the Settled Systems.

Separate expeditions recorded relatives apparently standing outside the hull and crew members entering maintenance locks to reach them. Recovery teams later found intact, empty suits and bodies that moved in vacuum. Several ships returned before their crews showed obvious symptoms; outbreaks subsequently appeared aboard vessels that had stayed closer to settled worlds. The surviving records leave the identity of the first affected expedition uncertain.

By Lapse 2, paired watches and mechanical airlock restrictions were common on long driftless voyages. Crews also covered viewports during scheduled periods and checked one another's identity and location aloud. These practices survive in spacer routines, including the habit of asking another watch officer to verify an unexplained sound outside the hull before investigating it.

Player Options

GROUNDING CHECK

ACTIVITY 10 MINUTES

AUDITORY CONCENTRATE MENTAL

You guide an afflicted creature through familiar memories, physical sensations, current surroundings, and independently verified facts.

Requirements You are trained in Diplomacy, Medicine, or Occultism; the target has an active form of Void Calling, is willing, within your reach, and able to perceive you.

Attempt a Diplomacy, Medicine, or Occultism check against the DC of the target's Void Calling affliction. The target is temporarily immune to further Grounding Checks for 8 hours.

Critical Success The target gains a +2 circumstance bonus to its next stage save against Void Calling. For 10 minutes, the target treats creatures within 30 feet as observed unless another effect would make them hidden or undetected.
Success The target gains a +1 circumstance bonus to its next stage save against Void Calling.
Failure You provide comfort but no mechanical benefit.
Critical Failure As failure.

A bonus from Grounding Check doesn't stack with the bonus from Treat Disease.

EMERGENCY GROUNDING ◆◆

CONCENTRATE MENTAL

Requirements You are trained in Medicine or Occultism; the target has active true Void Calling and is within your reach. Using Medicine requires a medkit and gives this activity the manipulate trait. Using Occultism requires a conscious, willing target that can perceive you and gives it the auditory trait.

You support the patient's failing coordination or guide them through a brief orientation to their surroundings. Attempt a Medicine or Occultism check against DC 27. The target is then immune to further Emergency Grounding attempts until after its next stage save.

Critical Success The target gains a +2 circumstance bonus to its next stage save against true Void Calling.
Success The target gains a +1 circumstance bonus to that save.
Failure or Critical Failure No effect.

Use the highest applicable circumstance bonus if the target also benefits from Grounding Check or Treat Disease.

VOIDWISE

FEAT 1

GENERAL SKILL

Prerequisites trained in Occultism

You have studied the symptoms, spacer traditions, and containment procedures associated with Void Calling.
You can use Occultism in place of Medicine to Treat Disease when the target is afflicted with either form of Void Calling.
While you can perceive at least one allied creature within 30 feet, you gain a +1 circumstance bonus to saving throws against Void Calling.

Void-Returned Archetype

Void-Returned Archetype

Some survivors of true Void Calling retain physical changes after the crisis ends. Their breathing may pause for several minutes, and injuries that should have killed them leave them conscious. Others hear voices through sealed hulls or sense a nearby person before seeing them. Spacers call these survivors **Void-Returned**.

A survivor may have a dormant infection or have been cured. Record that status separately from this archetype. A dormant infection continues progressing according to Void Calling's rules, and an infected survivor can transmit the disease while it is active. A cured survivor retains the abilities gained here.

Examinations inside a natural planetary atmosphere are inconclusive because the affliction is dormant there. The changes represented by these feats continue to function in atmosphere. A Void-Returned remains a living creature.

When a feat grants the cosmic trait, use the cosmic carrier rules: harmful stage effects are suppressed while the normal timer continues. Failures and critical failures hold the stage in either environment. Outside atmosphere, successful saves can reduce the infection to stage 1. In natural planetary atmosphere, recovery saves continue at stage 1 and can cure the infection. When temporary protection ends, use the current recorded stage and remaining interval, applying atmospheric suppression where relevant.

VOID-RETURNED DEDICATION FEAT 2

RARE ARCHETYPE DEDICATION

Prerequisites You survived true Void Calling at stage 2 or higher and subsequently brought the affliction into dormancy or were cured

A part of the solution to UNITY. You retained part of the physical adaptation that sustained you during the crisis.
You become trained in Occultism. If you were already trained in Occultism, you instead become trained in Void Calling Lore. If you were already trained in both, you become trained in another Lore skill of your choice.
You gain the Refuse the Call reaction.

Refuse the Call ↷

OCCULT

Frequency once per day
Trigger You would be reduced to 0 Hit Points by damage but would not be immediately killed.
Effect Your body repeats one of the changes that kept you alive during true Void Calling. You remain at 1 Hit Point and don't fall unconscious. For 1 minute, you gain the cosmic trait and are stupefied 1. If you are already stupefied, this effect doesn't increase the value of your stupefied condition.
Special You can't select another dedication feat until you have gained two other feats from the Void-Returned archetype.

VACUUM MEMORY

FEAT 4

ARCHETYPE OCCULT

Prerequisites Void-Returned Dedication

The physical changes left by Void Calling help you withstand exposure.
Choose cold or void. You gain resistance to the chosen damage type equal to half your level.
While you are outside a natural planetary atmosphere, this resistance applies to both cold and void damage.

SOMEONE YOU KNOW ↷

FEAT 4

ARCHETYPE ILLUSION MENTAL OCCULT VISUAL

Prerequisites Void-Returned Dedication
Frequency once every 10 minutes
Trigger A creature within 30 feet that can perceive you makes a Strike against you

For an instant, the attacker sees a familiar person from its memories where you are standing.
You are concealed from the triggering creature against the triggering Strike. It must attempt the normal DC 5 flat check to target you. After the Strike is resolved, the hallucination ends.
The creature doesn't necessarily understand what it saw, even if the Strike succeeds.

I KNOW THAT VOICE

FEAT 6

ARCHETYPE

Prerequisites Void-Returned Dedication

You have already heard a voice use your own memories against you.

You gain a +1 circumstance bonus to saving throws against mental effects. This bonus increases to +2 against auditory mental effects and mental effects that would control you, confuse you, compel your movement, or dictate how you spend your actions.

NO BREATH BETWEEN STARS

FEAT 8

ARCHETYPE OCCULT

Prerequisites Void-Returned Dedication

The temporary adaptation that once appeared only during the disease has become permanent. You gain the cosmic trait. You can survive the basic environmental effects of vacuum and don't need to breathe while in space or a vacuum.

This feat doesn't grant a fly Speed. If you have a fly Speed from another source, the cosmic trait allows you to use it normally in vacuum and zero gravity.

HEAR THEM THROUGH THE HULL

FEAT 8

ARCHETYPE OCCULT

Prerequisites Void-Returned Dedication

Empty space has never felt completely empty since you recovered.

You gain lifesense as an imprecise sense with a range of 30 feet. You perceive vital and void energies as faint voices, knocks, displaced movement, or the sensation that someone is standing just beyond your field of view.

This sense distinguishes living creatures from undead creatures but doesn't identify a specific creature by itself.

INVITATION FROM OUTSIDE

FEAT 10

ARCHETYPE AUDITORY CONCENTRATE INCAPACITATION MENTAL OCCULT

Prerequisites Void-Returned Dedication

Frequency once every 10 minutes

Choose one creature within 60 feet that can hear you. You speak in a voice drawn from the target's own memories and briefly show it a place, person, or emergency that appears to demand its immediate attention.

The target attempts a Will save against your class DC or spell DC, whichever is higher. This is a compulsion effect.

Choose an unoccupied point the target can perceive within 30 feet of it. Any movement caused by this ability must bring the target closer to that point and can't knowingly move it into hazardous terrain.

Critical Success The target is unaffected and is temporarily immune to Invitation from Outside for 10 minutes.

Success The target is frightened 1.

Failure The target is frightened 1. On its next turn, it must spend its first action Striding toward the chosen point if it is able to do so.

Critical Failure The target is frightened 2. On its next turn, it must spend its first two actions Striding toward the chosen point if it is able to do so.

CALLING RECOGNITION

FEAT 12

ARCHETYPE OCCULT

Prerequisites Hear Them Through the Hull

You recognize the particular disturbance produced when the Calling has already touched a mind.

The range of your lifesense increases to 60 feet.

Your lifesense is precise when detecting creatures with an active form of Void Calling, including asymptomatic cosmic carriers, and creatures created by Void Calling, such as Void-Drawn. For other living and undead creatures, it remains imprecise.

A dormant infection provides no recognizable signature. Within a natural planetary atmosphere, a carrier is detected using ordinary lifesense. A Void-Drawn remains a transformed creature and can still be detected precisely.

VOID-DRAWN RESURGENCE ◈

FEAT 16

ARCHETYPE CONCENTRATE OCCULT POLYMORPH

Prerequisites Void-Returned Dedication
Frequency once per day

You allow the changes left by Void Calling to complete themselves temporarily without surrendering your identity.

Your breathing stops. Your body becomes unnaturally cold. Your eyes reflect points of light that don't correspond to the surrounding stars, and your voice occasionally seems to originate from somewhere beside or behind you.

For 1 minute, you gain the following benefits:

- You gain 40 temporary Hit Points.
- You gain a fly Speed equal to your land Speed.
- You gain the cosmic trait.
- You gain darkvision. If you already have darkvision, you gain greater darkvision for the duration.
- You gain resistance 15 to cold and void damage.
- The first time each round that you deal damage to a creature with a Strike or spell, you deal an additional 2d6 mental or void damage, chosen when you deal the damage.

While transformed, you remain a living creature. You don't gain the undead trait or void healing, and you don't become a Void-Drawn when the transformation ends.